

religion ASARAM BAPU

The death of two young boys from the gurukul threatens to expose the godman's questionable rise from obscurity to riches

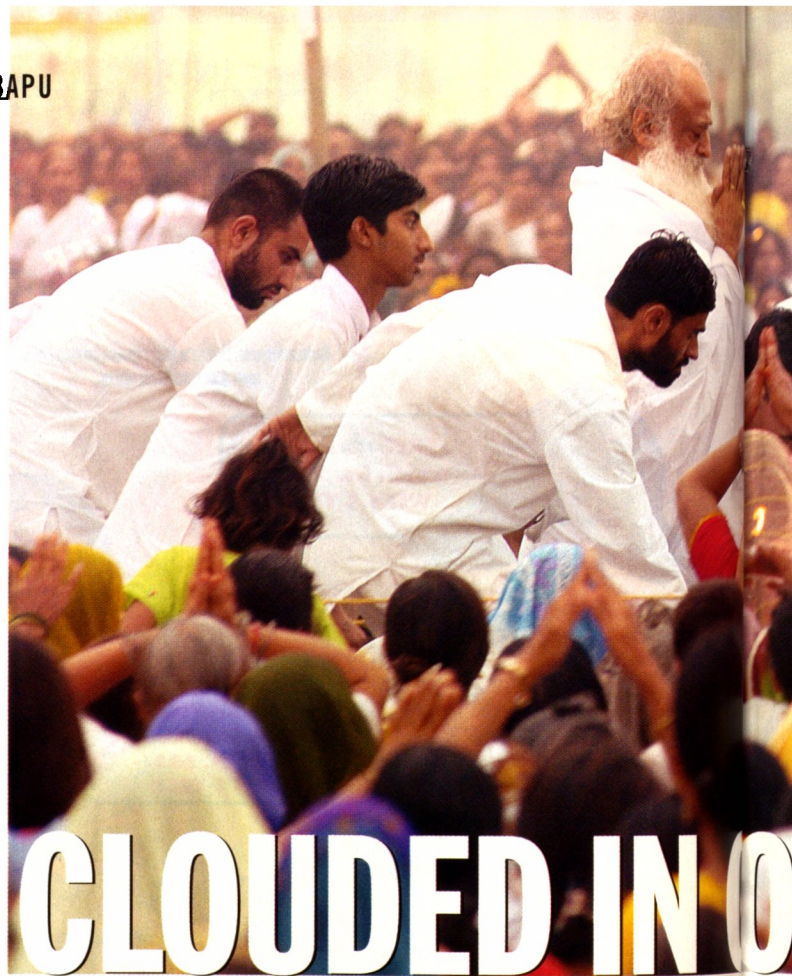
■ By Uday Mahurkar

India's spiritual arena is getting as murky as its political one. The latest manifestation of this was the mysterious death of two students in godman Asaram Bapu's ashram in Ahmedabad. Following allegations that the mysterious deaths of the boys were related to tantric rituals, Bapu's followers went on a rampage after they were beaten up by angry locals. They attacked journalists and burnt vehicles (see box). Even in the past, Bapu has been known to draw controversies. His rags to riches story is also questionable and fodder for debate.

From a mechanic at a cycle shop in Ahmedabad four decades ago to a spiritual guru with two crore followers and an empire worth Rs 5,000 crore, the rise of Asaram Bapu alias Asumal Thaumal Harpalani, 68, has been truly meteoric. He may rank a few rungs lower than other gurus when it comes to scriptures, but his wealth surpasses that of many of his contemporaries. His empire includes hundreds of acres of land in prime locations in India's major cities, a flourishing business of over two dozen products that includes a clutch of ayurvedic medicines, incense sticks, soaps and shampoos besides spiritual magazines that net crores of rupees for him annually. Bapu controls his country-wide empire through 400-odd trusts, of which two main ones—Sant Shri Asaramji Ashram Trust and Sant Shri Asaramji Mahila Utthan Trust—are based in Ahmedabad.

Fear and violence have been Bapu's hallmark, as the attack on reporters and others displayed. His diktat is enforced by his sadhaks (disciples), some of whom have also borne the brunt of his ire when they dared speak against some questionable activities in the ashram. They were terrorised and beaten up by their own fellowmen.

The latest to be hunted out of the Ahmedabad ashram is Dinesh Bhagchandani, 32, Bapu's former driver and man Friday. He was charged



with "indecent behaviour" with a sadhika (female disciple), an allegation his friends deny. Fearing for his life, Bhagchandani has fled Ahmedabad.

More than the fear factor is the money power the guru commands. Most of the controversies involving him relate to land deals across the country involving the ashram, which has 100 major centres located on huge tracts of land besides 1,200 satsang kendras. One of the newest imbroglio involves over 30 acres of land in Surat worth around Rs 125 crore. Bapu's disciples have encroached upon a part of government land on the banks of the Tapi river. The original owner from whom the Government had bought the land has moved the court pleading that if the Government's objective of making an embankment was not accomplished and someone else is the current owner, the land should be returned to him. Incidentally, land grabbing is one of the more serious charges that Bapu faces.

Another huge chunk of agriculture land bought five years ago by Bapu and his family members—his wife Lakshmiben, son Narayan, daughter Bharati and daughter-in-law Shilpa—in Pedmala in Sabarkantha district is also entangled in a legal wrangle. A local whistle blower, Ramesh Choksi, has complained to the district collector that the deal is illegal because Bapu and his family members bought the land by posing as farmers (only a farmer can buy agricultural land in Gujarat, according to the law). Choksi alleged that Bapu and his family had manipulated records to declare themselves as farmers. The collector has held Choksi's charges to be true. Says Choksi, "A look at the land-related court cases in which Bapu and his followers are involved across the country would show that they are one of the biggest land grabbers in India. The Government should blacklist them and seize all their lands."